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Dahomey, an ancient West African kingdom

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Document Type: Book

Original Page: 151

Culture (OWC): [Fon \(FA18\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Western Africa

Field Date: 1931

Coverage Date: 1930 AD - 1931 AD

Place Coverage: Dahomey

Section Title(S)

Chapter VIII KINSHIP GROUPS IN DAHOMEAN SOCIETY

After his fifth marriage the young man went on a journey that kept him away about a year, and it was not until after his return that he married his sixth wife. He called he *Yεkpéwǎ*, "I have no conquerors." This saying was a boast at the expense of an acquaintance who, having only two wives when this man had four, would never have more than half as many as he.

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The naming of a wife at the marriage ceremony is part of a complex of name-giving rituals that is deep-seated in Dahomean culture. In describing the ceremony for the installation of the *dokpwégâ*, it was remarked how the culminating moment was when the appointee arose and pronounced his new name. Every exploit in a man's life is signalized by the choice of a new name for himself, and a man's position in a community is enhanced by his resourcefulness in originating for himself ingenious names.¹ When a man who is about to marry is unable to devise a suitable name for his wife, it is possible for him to continue calling her by the name of her village or quarter. This, however, is regarded as inept and as cause for shame, so that a man who cannot think of a clever name for his new wife secretly has recourse to someone in the village, usually a singer who has shown talent in devising names, and this man, for a consideration, supplies him with a suitable name for the girl. At the opportune moment the bridegroom will, to be sure, pronounce it publicly as a name of his own invention.

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Another phase of Dahomean social organisation has to do with what has been aptly termed the "playmate" relationship and its associated taboos. In the present instance, information concerning these configurations developed from an analysis of the significance ¹152 of the terms employed by a person toward his spouse's grandparents. In address, a woman calls her husband's grandfather *asúchi*, "my husband," and this usage reflects the existence of a playmate relationship that prevails not only between persons who stand in this relationship to one another, but between numerous others. Thus, a woman may joke with all her husband's brothers, whether these brothers have the same mother or not, regardless of age, the reason for this being that when the husband dies, some of his wives become the wives of his brothers. However, although a man's sons may also inherit his wives, there is no joking between these sons and the wives of their father. A man may joke with his mother-in-law, in spite of the fact that the feeling between mother-in-law and son-in-law is ordinarily not too cordial. It was stated, indeed, that mothers-in-law and sons-in-law joke all the more for this reason. Parent-in-law taboos are evidently not found in this culture, though joking between a man and his father-in-law is not encouraged. Among the people who live at Agoli and Zagnanado it is customary for a man on meeting his father-in-law to cover his face, and it is also stated that in these districts these two must not eat out of the same dish. In Abomey, however, the only prohibitions are that a man may not sleep in the same room with his mother-in-law, or a woman with her father-in-law. Brothers-in-law are often very close friends, and sisters-in-law usually joke with each other, but this is only an indication of the freedom bred of more or less intimate everyday contact. A mother-in-law may joke with her daughter-in-law, because the mothers of both the bride and the groom supervise the first sexual contacts between a man and his wife. A man may not joke with his father's brothers, but he may do so with the brothers of his grandfather. A girl may not joke with her maternal aunts because it is said, "It is not a mother who corrects her child, but her sisters." However, since the mother's sisters are often with a mother, and girls may discuss all matters of sex with their mothers in the freest manner possible, a girl who wishes to speak to her mother of some intimate occurrence in the presence of a mother's sister will first pronounce the word *káflā*, "Do not listen to the words I am going to say." Having spoken this word, the girl may say anything she likes.¹

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¹ See Burton, vol. i, pp. 245–246, for a description of the scene when a new chief pronounced his "strong names" before Glele. Dalzel (pp. 156–158) gives in some detail the manner in which a new name was taken for himself by Kpɛngla.

¹ This word is also had recourse to in ordinary conversation, and after it has been spoken, anything may be said with social immunity from an angry reply.

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